

The Mughal Empire

The Mughal Empire was founded by Babur, a Muslim prince and descendant of the Mongol conqueror Genghis Khan. The Mughals' enormous wealth and power can still be seen today in the many great monuments they left behind.

- 1504** Babur captures the city of Kabul and becomes ruler of Afghanistan.
- 1526** Babur conquers Delhi in northern India. The Mughal age begins.
- 1540** Humayun, Babur's son, loses power to a rival Afghan dynasty but seizes it back in 1555.
- 1556** Babur's grandson, Akbar, becomes emperor.
- 1563** Akbar begins to pass laws granting Hindus religious and political freedom.
- 1605** Jahangir becomes emperor on Akbar's death.
- 1613** British East India Company allowed to build a warehouse in Surat, Gujarat.
- 1632** Emperor Shah Jahan begins building the Taj Mahal as a memorial to his wife Mumtaz Mahal.
- 1686** The East India Company starts a war with Emperor Aurangzeb over trading territory. After three years, the company admits defeat.
- 1739** Nadir, Shah of Persia, captures Delhi. The Mughal Empire starts to decline.
- 1707** Emperor Aurangzeb dies, triggering a period of rebellions.
- 1857** The last Mughal emperor, Bahadur Shah II, is deposed by the British for supporting the Indian Mutiny.



Akbar and his Hindu bride



Tomb of Mumtaz Mahal



Indian Mutiny, 1857

TIMELINE OF THE MUGHALS

The Mughals originally came from Central Asia. At their height, they ruled all of what is now northern India, Pakistan, Afghanistan, and Bangladesh. Only a century later, they had lost nearly all their territory.



MIGHTY MUGHALS

Babur and the strong rulers who came after him ensured that their empire grew steadily richer and more powerful.

- BABUR (1483–1530)**
A brilliant general, and also passionate about poetry and gardening. He wrote his own life story in the form of a diary, the *Baburnama*.
- AKBAR (1542–1605)**
Won the support of his people by setting fair taxes and promoting religious tolerance.
- JAHANGIR (1569–1627)**
An enthusiastic patron of the arts. His wife, Nur Jahan, was one of the most powerful women in Mughal history.
- SHAH JAHAN (1592–1666)**
Famed for the magnificence of his court, he built a new city, Shahjahanabad (now Old Delhi), as his capital.
- AURANGZEB (1618–1707)**
Expanded the empire by a quarter but the cost of military campaigns drained his treasury.



AKBAR'S TOMB

ARMOUR AND WEAPONS

Mughal warriors fought mostly on horseback, but they also used elephants that were specially trained to charge and trample the enemy during battle.



ASTRONOMY

Many Mughal emperors took a keen interest in science, mathematics, and especially astronomy. They built observatories and employed astronomers to produce detailed *zijes* (astronomical tables) and calendars.



JANTAR MANTAR OBSERVATORY, NEW DELHI (1724)
Built by order of the Emperor Muhammad Shah, to help create new astronomical tables.

